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Crises do strange things to people. Some ignore the danger as though they can make it go away by pretending it doesn't exist, which is how teams sleepwalk into danger as Tottenham appeared for much of this season to be doing. Once the cliff edge is acknowledged, there are those who find themselves drawn inexorably towards it in a vertigo of irresponsibility, clear thought rendered impossible, basic functions undermined. But there are others who, in extremis, find the brain clears and sinews stiffened, petty irritations melting away as focus sharpens.

In certain cases, that may not be enough. Sometimes, almost whatever you do, the pull of the abyss is too strong to be resisted. Tottenham had seemed to be dragging themselves together. The last week has been broadly positive. They began extremely well against [Nottingham Forest](#).

They could easily have had a comfortable lead before half-time. But they couldn't score, Forest did, anxiety began to freeze brains and suddenly all they can see are the lines whooshing past as they plummet towards the Championship. And this was them playing quite well; they may not do that too often in what remains of the season.

Fans are – understandably – unhappy with much about the running of the club, but there comes a point when dissatisfaction has to take a back seat to fighting off the mounting threat of relegation: who cares about petty family squabbles when the undead are massing beyond the wall? Taking inspiration from Everton and [their successful scraps against the drop](#), a large group of fans gathered to greet the bus as it arrived. There was blue and white smoke, banners proclaiming undying love and a general sense of resolve and unity in the face of danger. Igor Tudor proclaimed himself "emotional" at the scenes.

There had been encouraging signs from the team as well in the previous two games. Whether the [draw at Anfield](#) was more to do with Liverpool's shortcomings or returning Spurs spirit was debatable, but the point stopped the rot of six straight defeats and demonstrated a measure of fight that had not been apparent in Tudor's first four games as manager. That sense of a team battling continued in the [3-2 win over Atlético](#) on Wednesday. It may not have meant anything in terms of overturning the first-leg deficit, but it restored a little pride, a little faith.

Spurs began, for the first time in weeks, playing with belief. There was pace and conviction. Archie Gray was stroking it around in midfield. Mathys Tel made some dangerous incursions from the left.

Richarlison, always a nuisance to somebody, was bothering the Forest back four. Twice before half-time Spurs hit the woodwork. Richarlison put a header across the face and just wide of the far post. It felt as though a goal had to come.

And yet Spurs went behind just before the break. It stemmed from almost nothing, a speculative, - mis-hit Igor Jesus volley tipped over by Guglielmo Vicario. Then Neco Williams dropped his corner amid a crowd at the back post and Jesus headed in. The abyss sucks in even the most careful wanderers. There were boos at half-time, although it would be hard to explain at what. Surely not at a Spurs team who had probably their best half in the league since the comeback against Manchester City? Surely not at Tudor, whose tough love does seem to be bringing some sort of reaction? Perhaps simply at the fates, at the way, no matter what Spurs do, relegation becomes a more realistic threat with each passing week.

In the second half, predictably enough, Spurs were unable to return to the heights of the first. The

confidence had gone and with it the crispness of their passing and purposefulness of approach. Williams could have added a second for Forest, Morgan Gibbs?White did and Taiwo Awoniyi got a third.

This was the game that many had earmarked as decisive. However bad things got, there was still the knowledge for Spurs fans that they had a home game against a fellow struggler, one without a win in seven league games, with just two league wins all year. Win that and they would open clear water; win that and they could breathe easier. But they did not win it, and so the mood by the end was a strange mix of panic and resignation.

At least [West Ham also lost](#) and Leeds [failed to win](#) this weekend. Tottenham are not in the relegation zone yet. But they have still not won a game this year and there must be a thought of replacing Tudor during the international break, if only because it feels like something must be done and that is something. If the rolls of this dice aren't working, try another dice.

The abyss is drawing Spurs in, and there's no sign of them being able to resist its call.

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